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Disciplinary commitments of history and reading practices of historical writing

ABSTRACT

In the paper I attempt to partially answer the question of the relationship between the articulation of historical knowledge and its consumption. I question the statements often made in the discussions of historical theorists, namely that immersive reading distorts or reduces, or perhaps blocks, knowledge-oriented reading and violates the integrity of the historical knowledge produced. I discuss the relationship between immersive and knowledge-oriented reading by setting them within the broader spectrum of reading practices. In doing so, I draw on Rita Felski's work on reading fictional literature. In considering the comparison of different modes of reading historical writing, I look at the reading practices of historical writing in general and the relationships between these practices. I describe the different reading practices of historiography: enchantment and shock, identification, empathy, recognition and knowledge. With the help of these categories, I describe the reading practices of historical writing that I have observed in historians' more or less formal, frequently autobiographical contributions about reading history books, the literature on reading and fan practices, the instructions that, typically in the introductions to their books, historians give to their audiences, reviews of historical literature, and articles covering historical debates. I also included readers' contributions posted on *goodreads.com* - the world's largest social media platform dedicated to reading. I argue that, first, reading practices like enchantment and shock, identification, empathy, recognition are not opposed to knowledge-oriented reading or critical thinking, and second, mutual cooperation of different reading modes can serve to produce historical knowledge. Rather than considering how to avoid these components of reading, it is better to consider whether they are useful for the basic function of historical writing.

Keywords: historical writing, reader response, consumption of history, research commitments of history, reading practices

INTRODUCTION

I have been interested in democratic historical writing and by democratic I mean, first and foremost, egalitarian writing, that is, writing that seeks to avoid reproducing hierarchical relationships between authors, texts, readers and past actors, as well as between academic disciplines and society. One of the questions I address concerns historians' communication with the public, the important objects of which is the production and transfer of historical knowledge. The question is how to frame the relationship between the articulation of knowledge and its consumption.¹

Studies on the consumption of history most often address the question of the circulation of historical knowledge outside the academy and, above all, the process of its production, remaking and resonance in contemporary popular culture. For example in his books Jerome De Groot looks at how different forms of non-academic historical culture represent the past and to what extent they produce critical knowledge (de Groot 2008; de Groot 2016). Sociologists have long conducted studies on the consumption of various cultural objects and performances, focusing on forms of strong engagement with reception practices that are important to me. However, these studies are confined to fan groups of popular culture, fans of Star Trek, the Greatful Dead or soap operas (Jindra 1994; Adams 1998; Harrington, Bielby 1995). As Claudio Benzacry, a researcher of Argentine opera fans, has observed, there is a lack of studies about lovers of cultural forms perceived as high-brow. The democratisation of cultural studies encounters its limit here: the conviction that strong fan engagement with culture can only apply to popular culture (Benzecry 2011). What I am concerned with in this paper is the reception of academic historical writing by historical book lovers (both academic and non-academic), or in other words, I am interested in different practices of reading professional historical writing and the outcomes of these readings.

Historians and theorists tend to address the question of how to frame the relationship between the articulation of knowledge and its consumption when discussing non-academic

¹ Reading practices, including historical writing, are multiple. They involve a variety of ways of reading texts, including comprehension and interpretation. The study of reading practices draws on both what is known as reading response research and cultural consumption studies. I will therefore use these terms as equivalents.

historical representations: museum exhibitions, films, novels or computer games. What these past-talks are supposed to have in common is to suggest to their audiences a reading practice that is aimed more at immersion into the historical world than the acquisition of knowledge. Immersion itself is generally defined as a strong emotional and psychological engagement with a given representation that causes audiences to disconnect from their surroundings and immerse themselves in the world produced by the representation. Audiences' commitment to the fictional world may cause them to temporarily equate it with the world outside the representation (Bolter and Grusin, 1999: 21-50; Wolf, 2013).

In this regard, the following question is sometimes debated: to what extent does the immersive reading of historical representations affect their function of providing knowledge. Some replies say that immersion in historical books or articles engages the audience and supports the production and reception of historical knowledge in different ways, others that immersion distorts or reduces or perhaps blocks knowledge-oriented response and violates the integrity of the knowledge transmitted. The first group generally includes scholars who study different forms of representation of history (de Groot 2016, Landsberg 2015); the second group often includes very different critics of the inclusion of affects in the production of historical knowledge (Agnew 2007; Tucker 2024).

An example of such a claim is Wulf Kansteiner's introduction to the 2018 *Memory Studies* volume on the relationship between history, memory and movies. There, the author argues that historical films should be analysed by memory scholars rather than historians, precisely because of the immersive nature of these representations. Kansteiner points out that the experience of immersion is not alien to historians, as they subject themselves to it in the early stages of the production of historical representations. Historians establish a passionate, intimate relationship with the past and its actors by working over long periods of time with archives. Arlette Farge wrote about this in *Le goût de l'archive*. Often the past they study becomes closer to them than the present. However, Kansteiner emphasises that in the later stages of their work, and during the construction of a historical representations, historians will try to produce an objective and distanced narrative about the past, which inhibits the impulses to emotional engagement on the part of the reading public (Kansteiner 2018).

The production of historical writing is therefore a process that runs from emotional to intellectual engagement, while filmmaking runs in the opposite direction. Film-makers move from the objectified historical knowledge provided by historical writing to emotionally and personally engaging images of the past. These movements in opposite directions, in Kansteiner's opinion, are the reason for the misunderstanding between the two groups.

Memory scholars are willing to study films because, for them, it is precisely those representations of the past that generate a reading oriented towards strong emotional engagement that are more interesting.

Another example can be found in the contributions of Kalle Pihlainen, one of the few scholars working on audiences' responses to historical writing. In a recent article, he addresses the relationship between the referential rules of the genre (historical writing) and the immersive practices of the readers. In his view, there is a great tension between these two components of historical writing. At the end of the article, Pihlainen proposes to three objectives to theorists of history, towards which they could work. One is to look for writing strategies to support readers of historical writing in a reading that focuses on references to the past and avoids immersion. He points out that readers generally submit to the rules of the genre reading contract, which assigns them the task of following (and critically processing) references to the past. However, when readers choose an immersion-centred reading mode, historians could attempt to persuade them out of such an approach with suitable writing procedures and reinforcement of the referential component (Pihlainen 2019).

We should explore strategies that help readers read for reference and refuse immersion [...] We may want to persuade readers out of immersive attitudes by changing our representational strategies and reinforcing the material connection in the text (by increasing complexity, inducing confusion, appealing to disruptive embodied experiences, and so on) (Pihlainen 2019: 76)

What Kansteiner's observations and Pihlainen's call have in common, I believe, is the assumption of an oppositional relationship between modes of reading. Kansteiner writes about the two opposing directions in which historians and filmmakers tend to go in their activities: the former aims to produce and transfer knowledge, the latter to create the conditions for engagement (and many other groups producing historical culture could also be substituted here: museum professionals, computer game producers or fiction writers). Pihlainen articulates this assumption in the form of one of the calls for future work by historical theorists: the development of historical writing procedures that steer reading towards knowledge.

The opposition of immersive reading and knowledge-centred reading, and the arguments supporting it, raise questions: Can historical writing be read in two ways simultaneously: for knowledge and for emotional engagement? Is the assumption that

immersion-oriented reading is opposed to knowledge-seeking reading accurate? Do these two reading practices really compete with each other for the reader's attention? I think these are important issues, because at stake in resolving these is, at least in part, the social role of history, for which the question of the readership of historical writing is central.

In this paper I ask about the relationship between different modes of reading historical writing. I will attempt to address this by describing the different modes of reading undertaken by audiences of historical writing. I situate the often encountered oppositional interpretation of modes of reading; on the one hand those oriented towards the acquisition of knowledge; and on the other those oriented towards a strong and personal engagement with the representation, within a broader spectrum of reading practices.

In doing so, I will draw heavily on the work of literary scholar Rita Felski (2008; 2015, 2020), who addresses the question of reading practices.² I will adapt her approach to discuss reader responses to historical writing. In considering whether the opposing of different uses of historical writing is valid, I will take into consideration the reading practices of historical writing in general and the relationship between these practices. I am interested in whether these practices can work together, perhaps even driving each other's productivity, or whether they compete with each other for readers' attention.

I am interested here in the practices of consumers of historical writing, both professional and ordinary history fans. Indeed, I would also like to challenge at once the distinction between two groups of readers. Academic readers used to be regular readers and still are by using non-professional reading practices. Moreover, academic readers, like non-academic readers, invest a lot of affection and become attached to their reading, if only because they devote a lot of time and energy to reading, which is part of their professional duties. At the same time, ordinary readers are not, after all, deprived of reading training; non-academics have many opportunities to come into contact with academic reading practices. All of them encounter professional reading practices at school, some of them exercise them on social websites like *Goodreads*, whilst others read reviews in the press or take part in book clubs.

There are also other reasons to challenge this distinction. Re-evaluating the relationship between academic and ordinary readers can serve to bridge the social divide and abolish the hierarchical relationship between academic historians and their audiences. Since these modes

² To date, Felski's proposition and the postcritique have not been used at all in the theory of history, apart from an article by Herman Paul (2022) in which he discusses how the humanities relate to their ethos and to themselves using figures of turns and 'posts'.

of reading are not fundamentally different, the two groups will find it easier to communicate with each other. This will, I believe, make the social engagement of history more democratic and productive: historians will establish a more equal relationship with their audiences, rather than try to rescue them from ignorance.

In the paper mentioned earlier, Wulf Kanstainer, implicitly suggested that historians' strong engagement in reading concerns their relationship with archival records and, to a lesser extent, with historical writing. I am aware of the fact that a large part of the reading of scholars and students is of an extensive nature, i.e. they often quickly skim through the texts, only read abstracts, introductions, conclusions or fragments that are important for their current research, make notes of relevant information and stop reading (Sachs 2010: 8, 23). This approach rarely produces more than an operational, distanced engagement. This is particularly the case for those books and articles whose form has been subordinated to a large extent to the IMRAD format. An extensive reading mode, hardly attempted by lay readers, would therefore remain an element that distinguishes the two groups of readers. Academic historians, however, do undertake engaged readings of their colleagues' works, as evidenced by heated, emotional reviews and polemics. The temperature of the discussions testifies not only to the authors' deep bond with their books, as engaged positions are also taken by their critics, but also to a strong connections with historical actors, research methods and topics.

I also assume that reading a particular history book is always mediated (Rigney 2010). I function in a media environment in which reading a book about the social history of the 1960s in the US will be mediated by the TV series *Mad Men* (2007-2015), reading about the war in Former Yugoslavia in 90's by playing the game *This War of Mine* (11bit, 2014), and reading about the history of Romani in Poland by artistic installation *Re-enchanting the World* by Małgorzata Mirga-Tas exhibited at Venice Biennale in 2022. Moreover, these representations are already mediated by other representations as well as comments, recommendations of teachers, friends, curators, reviewers, or even interventions of politicians. My reading is mediated not only by past readings, but also by how I want to use my reading in the future. Here, I agree with Pierre Bourdieu that reading is undertaken with a certain social market of opinion in mind, where I can voice what I think about the book (Chartier, Bourdieu 1993).

Now I would like to discuss some practices of reading that I believe readers of historical writing have. In doing so, I use categories borrowed from the work of the aforementioned Felski, who uses them to describe the practices of fiction readers. These categories are enchantment and shock, identification, empathy, and recognition. With the help of them, I describe the reading practices of historical writing that I have observed in historians' more or

less formal, frequently autobiographical contributions about reading history books, in the literature on reading and fan practices, in the instructions that, typically in the introductions to their books and papers, historians give to their audiences, in reviews of historical literature and in articles covering historical debates. Another collection of information on reading historical writing is an analysis of readers contributions posted on *goodreads.com* - the world's largest social media platform dedicated to reading, a form of networked book club with global reach (140 million users). Along with novels, biographies and memoirs, historiography is the main writing genre discussed on the platform. In my analysis, I focused on contributions to one book, *The Comanche Empire* by Pekka Hämäläinen from 2008. I chose it because of the diversity of the book's audience - it was read by both professional and non-professional fans of historical writing, including history theorists.³ More than 1,500 ratings of the book have been published on the platform, of which 185 are accompanied by shorter or longer reviews (sometimes a few words, other times several hundred). Readers summarised the book, were enthusiastic about it, were sometimes dissatisfied with its large size, detail and numerous repetitions, shared how the book connected to their personal experiences and finally praised the book's argumentation and its new interpretation of the history of the 18th and 19th centuries of the American Southwest.⁴

KNOWLEDGE

Before I begin to describe the practices of reading historical writing, I will simply point out that one of them is knowledge-oriented reading. The rules of historical writing as a genre require historians to present solid historical knowledge, while readers are required to do reading oriented at exploring this knowledge. For a historical writing to provide knowledge, the readers must cooperate with it. Their reading involves discerning facts, associating them with evidence by confronting footnotes or cited source content, critically following the analysis of data, tracking the argument and evaluating its relevance, comparing incoming information with the knowledge they already have (Pihlainen 2017).

Lay history books lovers are interested in acquiring knowledge, which they use less to produce new knowledge (this is the goal of professional historians) and more to satisfy their curiosity, to experience the pleasure of being surprised and discovering something new, or to produce an opinion on a topic which is more or less up-to-date in public debate. Such

³ The February 2013 History and Theory volume included a forum on Pekka Hämäläinen's book.

⁴ The book's entry on *goodreads* can be found at: <https://www.goodreads.com/book/show/3304956-the-comanche-empire>.

intuitions are confirmed by readers' comments on *The Comanche Empire*. Readers felt repeatedly surprised by the book, especially its reinterpretation of familiar North American history. Its novelty, its transgression of established conventions depicting this fragment of history, and its overcoming of stereotypes, such as the noble savage, pleased them. Several of them indicated that the book helped them think about contemporary issues, such as the 2014-2016 protest against the construction of the Dakota Access Pipeline or the policies of the United States towards authoritarian regimes.

ENCHANTMENT AND SHOCK

One practice of reading historical writing can be described by the term enchantment. Readers immerse themselves in the world of historical books, and intense pleasure is accompanied by a feeling of detachment and surrender to reading. The feeling of detachment from contemporary reality can be linked to the desire often observed in readers to escape from the contemporary world and immerse themselves in their favourite historical period. However, the detachment from the present leads here to the making of new connections: with historical actors and with the representation of the past world. The sensation of surrender, in turn, is to give up control and one's own autonomy to reading in order to enter the representation of the past all the more deeply.

For historians and other ardent fans of history, this immersion in the past can take the form reported by J.H. Hexter in his article "The Historian and His Day." In it, Hexter argues against the long-recurring argument in discussions of historical knowledge proclaiming that we always study the past from a contemporary perspective, bringing into our research process, often unwittingly, issues and beliefs related to our present. He recounts his typical day filled with classes at the university, reading historical records and literature, writing and sometimes discussions, the vast majority of which are about the past. He concludes from this that his today is not the United States of the 1950s (when he was writing) but early modern England, which is his main field of research. His view of the past is not guided by twentieth-century political disputes, myths and emotions, but conversely, it is early modern political disputes, myths and emotions that guide him in his twentieth-century life (Hexter 1954).

The practice of shock is similar to enchantment, but has a different direction. Both are very intense, consisting of a loss of control and a sense of detachment, but while enchantment is associated with pleasure, shock is an ambivalent or even unpleasant experience. Under enchantment I experience a sense of enthusiasm and confidence, while shocked I feel disorientation and anxiety. I'm talking here about a feeling that has often been captured in

humanities using such categories as transgression, defamiliarisation, sublime, trauma. It seems that historical writing, especially that which deals with the history of various forms of violence, can evoke this kind of feeling in the reader. History books can be a source not only of knowledge, entertainment, or warm feelings, but also of fear, uncertainty, or disgust.

About the sublime historical experience that could accompany the reading of historical writing, Frank Ankersmit wrote that it consisted of a simultaneously occurring sense of loss and reclamation of the past. In his view, such an experience was individual and accidental - it was the stock of a reader's individual experience in encountering an element of the text that triggered such a reading reaction (and not some feature of the writing) (Ankersmit 2004). The experience of transgression in reading historiography was described in a different way by Dominick LaCapra, pointing to specific experimental articulations of liminal events in the works of Michel Foucault's *History of Madness* and Michel De Certeau's *Possession at Loudun* (LaCapra 2000; LaCapra 2004).

It is easy to oppose practices described in this way with reading for knowledge and critical thinking. The latter used to be associated with a sober attitude that preserves the reader's autonomy from reading. However, the immersive reading of a history book – and it is the same with other cultural objects – consists of the practice of oscillating between being swept away by a representation of the past, and the awareness of surrendering to this experience. Readers often engage in such a reading with a double or ironic awareness: on the one hand, they succumb to the enchantment or shock, while on the other, they remain on the outside of the experience and look at their own response to the reading. This is how some readers perceived *The Comanche Empire*, however they viewed the shift from immersion in the world of the Comanche empire to a critical reconfiguration of knowledge triggered by a new interpretive framework as a rhetorical device written into the text by the author.

An example of declaring an intention to shock the reader, but one that is meant to take the form of a reaction that is both emotional and intellectual, is the ending of the introduction to Saul Friedländer's book *The Years of Extermination*. There, Friedländer describes an experience of disbelief. It is to be evoked by the testimonies and photographs of the everyday reality of the persecution and extermination of the Jews included in the book. The impression of disbelief is supposed to be an embodied, sudden and immediate reaction that precedes knowledge and its soothing effect. Friedländer entrusts his readers' reaction with the task of disrupting and questioning the historical narrative he is pursuing and demonstrating that a part of the horror of the Holocaust escapes structured knowledge. The reader is supposed to

constantly oscillate between the sensation of shock and the attentive consumption of knowledge (Friedländer 2007).

Consideration of enchantment and shock in the reading practice of historical writing allows to note that readers can undertake several reading practices at the same time or move from one to another: from enchantment to identification, then to shock, followed up by an orientation toward knowledge acquisition, and again to enchantment. What is more, combining different reading modes can be productive for them – entering one mode can trigger engagement in another.

IDENTIFICATION

What does it mean to identify with a history book? Felski suggests that readers' identification should be understood according to the use of the word in common language. Identification is a relationship based on similarity, in other words, on the readers having a similar features with the historical figures. Historical beings become models of behaviour, negative examples, moral authorities, objects of fascination, friends, adversaries.

Identification can take complex forms. First, it does not have to mean only sympathy for a given historical figures – it can be combined with an ambivalent or even negative attitude towards them. Readers may recognize some of their own qualities in characters or groups, but relate to them with dislike. For example, readers recognise the patriarchal heritage of their society, but condemn past gender inequalities. Second, shared qualities with characters can either drive identification (this occurs when the qualities of ourselves and the character were known to us) or can only be produced by identification (when, under the influence of reading, we 'recognise' our own feature or when we attribute some feature to the characters for various reasons). Connected with the latter case is the practice of anachronism when, in the course of identification, we attribute qualities to past characters that are important to our contemporary process of self-understanding. Third, identification looks for commonalities, but it also pays a lot of attention to differences. It triggers the practice of discerning in which configurations the shared qualities occur in historical figures. Fourth and finally, identification can be either hampering or productive: one identification can shut down the reader to further links or just trigger more, it can merge and erase social categories, but it can also lead to entrenchment in the identity positions suggested. Identification with a particular heroine, for example, Marie Curie-Skłodowska, may prompt the reader to focus only on her, but may also propel the reader to identify with other chemists, women, scientists, Curie-Skłodowska's family, Poles, French.

One reader of *The Comanche Empire* concluded a longer commentary, in which he spent a lot of time praising the book for building a complex picture of the Comanche, with the words: ‘as much as I loved this book and its deep dive into Comanche history, and seeing them as a vibrant, adaptable, and formidable people, I also kept thinking <Yeah, but really... they were pretty terrible>.’⁵ The reader is fascinated by the book and its characters, the Comanches; he follows their story attentively and admires their ability to take advantage of difficult historical conditions to build a strong political entity. At the same time, their means of operation, especially their ruthlessness, aggressiveness and cruelty, disgusts him. He identifies with this group, cheers them on in dealing with the odds, and at the same time their practices repel him.

Who can one identify with when reading a history book? Identification does not have to be with individual people, but also with classes, nations, regions, cities, minority groups, ideas, professional groups, political groups, things (such as railroads, cars, industrial plants, buildings, types of weapons), social processes (recently, the object of more than intellectual interest is the process of upward social mobility). Identification can cut across divisions of gender, race, sexuality, class, or even, in environmental history, species. Feminist and queer cultural studies have produced a number of interesting works on reading practices that make identification across identity divisions (Fuss 1995; Palacios 2020). For example, young non-heterosexual readers of *The Diary of Anne Frank* make a surprising, and what could be judged controversial (because it marginalises the memory of the Holocaust) identification with its author, which targets her queerness and girlhood (Jakobsen 2022). It is also safe to assume that readers of Éric Baratay's books (e.g. Baratay 2021) on animal history will identify with their characters and readers of Peter Ackroyd's (2007) biography of the Thames, with the river.

Readers can also identify with historical ideas. There are fans of the history of capitalism, the climate crisis, postcolonialism, and human rights. Of course, the strength of their attraction is partly due to the heated arguments about these ideas in the public debate. One can also associate with intellectual figures or simply authors of history books: Fernand Braudel,⁶ Michel Foucault, Joan Scott, David Christian, Yuval Noah Harari (Moran 1998; McKee 2007). Audiences may become attached to a particular history book author and read

⁵ A comment by “David”: <https://www.goodreads.com/book/show/3304956-the-comanche-empire>.

⁶ Lise Sedrez (California State University): “I admit, I am a big Braudel fan; sue me“. Por. Richard C. Hoffmann, Nancy Langston, James C. McCann, Peter C. Perdue, Lise Sedrez, “AHR Conversation: Environmental Historians and Environmental Crisis”, *The American Historical Review* 113, 5, December 2008: 1433.

everything they have written, take an interest in their biographies, go to authors meetings, read interviews and book reviews.

Characters can be different historical beings. It is enough that they act and respond, have some purpose or motivation. Unlike in fiction, historians cannot depict their thought processes and feelings in detail. But characters may be only partially described, coherent or psychologically complex for us to identify with them. As cartoonists suggest, it is sometimes more productive to use a few apt lines than a detailed realistic image (Burt and Waldman 2022). Characters just need to stand out with something readers will do the rest of the job of filling in their depiction.

Readers who are attached to a characters look for them in subsequent history books, as well as TV series, museum exhibitions or historical novels. Characters are not attached to the books in which they first appeared, but by appearing in other works they push the audience to read, see, hear, and experience more.

Readers engaged with a historical figure, such as Napoleon, look for him in subsequent history books, as well as TV series, museum exhibitions or historical novels. Appearing in other versions of the character pushes the viewers to read more. The staging of characters in various writings and other media, as well as famous actors and the historical figures they portray in film performances, can blend together in the audience's perception. Historical film characters, fictional and real, staged by Daniel Day-Lewis may not only seem similar in some characteristics to the audience, even despite the huge differences between, say, Abraham Lincoln (*Lincoln*), Reynolds Woodcock (*Phantom Thread*), Daniel Plainview (*There Will Be Blood*) or Bill Butcher (*Gangs of New York*), but also lead them from the history of abolitionism and the Civil War, to the history of British fashion in the 1950s, or the history of social conflicts in California of the early 20th century, to the people's history of 19th century New York City (Cullen 2013).

EMPATHY

Two types of reader identification with historical writing worthy of particular attention are empathy and recognition. Empathy is the process of cognitive, emotional and imaginative insight into and understanding of someone's feelings and thoughts, as well as sharing and responding attentively to that person's feelings and thoughts, while acknowledging that person's distinctiveness. Empathy has repeatedly been reflected upon by historians as a component of historical understanding, but it has never gained a prominent place in historical theory. Tyson Retz and Taynna Marino have recently reminded us of this (Retz 2018; Marino

2022). This mode of reading is, on the one hand, a component of historical inquiry and, on the other, remains an important reading practice of lay history fans.

Empathy is regarded with suspicion as a practice that leads to a too easy, uncritical and sentimental putting oneself in the shoes of other people and groups. For example, when privileged contemporary readers give in to the illusion that they know what it was like to be, say, a female worker in the tobacco factories of pre-war Krakow.

Empathy, however, can take a more complex form, in which the cognitive and emotional components cooperate and negotiate with each other, but also constrain one another. What we have here is not simply a distanced observation of the past, but the production of generally temporary bonds with its actors and addressing them in a way that is responsible and sensitive to their dignity and individuality. In this type of reading, the readers do not have full control over the affective component, but it is inhibited and supplemented by the cognitive component aiming at critical receptivity, which in turn is blocked again by the emotional reactions of the reader. It seems that the cooperation of the two components is a prerequisite for the effectiveness of such reading, and efforts to enhance the critical disposition at the expense of the affective one could weaken this type of reader response. The notion of empathy helps to bring together what some other modes of reading try to separate: critical thinking and emotional modes of response.

RECOGNITION

What does it mean then to recognise oneself in a book? As with the practice of identification, the reader compares his or her self with the characters, focusing more attention, however, on experiencing oneself, self-discovery, learning something about oneself. In addition to the emotional, this practice has a reflective component, as reading makes me come to know and feel about myself in an updated or different way.

The category of recognition plays a large role in political and social studies in the context of struggles for social and political recognition. Different groups may demand recognition, i.e. public acknowledgement of their dignity and equal participation in society by the general public. The ongoing interest in the struggle for recognition, which has been under way for several decades, is due, among other things, to the observed efforts of various groups in society to demand recognition: ethnic or racial minorities, women, LGBTQ groups, people with disabilities, or sex workers. The use of the word struggle suggests that the process of recognition of a given group rarely takes a harmonious form and meets with social

understanding, rather, it takes the form of conflict or it generates divisions and often forces a painful resignation of part of one's identity.

How does the issue of struggle for recognition relate to the reading of historical writing? First, practices of self-recognition can inspire self-acknowledgement and also participation in the struggles for social recognition. Reading historical writing can provide me with an experience of belonging; a sense that I am not alone and that there were others who thought and felt as I did. I stop feeling invisible and realise that my qualities can be recognised as desirable and socially important. It can also lead the reader to identify – always risky – with the interests of another group and take sides in the struggle for recognition: on the side of the former popular classes (of which we are most often descendants), the Native Americans, the victims of the violence of the Second World War, against whom the process of recognising that their deaths are worthy of mourning is still underway (Zinn 2003; Sendyka 2021). Second, the struggle for social recognition can use historical writing to achieve its goals. The visibility of a particular group in historical discourse, let say women historians, strengthens its position in society. Third, history books can serve as a laboratory for social recognition by providing knowledge of how the construction of a sense of community and self-knowledge, as well as the struggles of groups, have taken place in the past.

With regard to historical writing, it seems that a key role is played by the mechanism of recognition binding readers to national groups or states. The relationship between historical writing, the state apparatus and nationalism, as well as history nationalist or state origins, has been written about extensively (Berger, Lorenz 2010). Historical writing has very often called, and continues to call on its readers to become more or less actively involved in the national or state community, to recognise in themselves a Brazilian, an Iranian or a Pole, and to claim their national or state history as their own. Reading history books can be about succumbing to these mechanisms of power, but it can also become a practice of testing different forms of national and state belonging. Readers can use history as a device with which to consider the different ways in which an individual enters a community.

CONCLUSION

I think I have at least partly succeeded above in showing that Felski's observations and insights on literary readership are tenable in relation to historical writing. Reading practices for both genres of writing are similar. I believe the intuition that there is considerable overlap between the two reading groups and that reading habits developed with one type of writing work well with the other is accurate.

Applying them here has also allowed me to tease out several differences between the two genres. Firstly, the reader's process of identification with the historical actor will not be able to rely on insights into the character's thoughts in most cases – here fiction has an advantage over historical writing. Secondly, in the case of historical writing, we have to deal with genre rules that impose on readers the task of treating the text as a vehicle for knowledge, which, although literary writing can fulfil such functions, are not its genre feature. Thirdly, historical writing is more often read in a quick, utilitarian, extensive way, and this rarely happens to literature.

To conclude my remarks on the reading practices of historical writing I would like to return to the question of the relationship between fact-centred reading and immersive reading, and thus ask whether enchantment, shock, identification, empathy and recognition comes into conflict or competition with knowledge-oriented reading. In other words, whether these ways of reading must be contained or suppressed in order for historical writing as a genre to fulfil its distinctive function.

As I hope I have been able to show above, these reading practices are not opposed to knowledge-centred reading or critical thinking. While strongly linked to emotions, they are also critical and involve a mixture of feeling and thinking. For example, in the process of identification, we can rethink and question our own identity and the identity of others, the self-understanding of our own group and other groups, the differences between contemporary forms of identity and those of the past. Historical writing also provides awareness about the limits of self-knowledge by presenting characters who made inaccurate or incomplete identifications of themselves and others.

It is worth noting that previous theoretical accounts of reader response agree that it is essentially beyond the control of authors and the text (Tompkins 1995). Reading is based on the conditioned personal and collective cultural experience, combines processes and generates meanings, senses, and images which have a vast number of variants. Authors and the text itself, of course, can design reading response, but their effectiveness in doing so depends on the cooperation of the reader.

At this point in the argument, the question may arise as to the extent to which immersive, consumerist reception offers too easy and straightforward a reading experience and, as a result, does not serve the purpose of engaging in the presentation of the past. Researchers of the consumption of history respond with the claim that such practices are participatory, engaging, activating and attach audiences to, among other things, historical

writing, and justify it by citing numerous examples of such reception practices (De Groot 2008).

It is the attempts to control the response of historical writing and inhibit certain modes of reading that can limit its resonance. According to Wai Chee Dimock, a researcher of reading response, the most successful writing is not that which, through the use of clever, persuasive solutions maintains its integrity despite the distracting, dismantling, stratifying forces of reader response, but that which yields to them. For such writing resonates most strongly. Dimock explains her position by contrasting it with Harlod Bloom's (1994) ideas: 'A theory of resonance inverts the Bloomian hypothesis, by linking literary endurance not to the persistent integrity of the text but to its persistent unravelling, not to the text's timeless strength but to something like its timeful unwieldiness. The note a text resounds comes from its lack of insulation against the currents of semantic change.' (Dimock 1997: 1062)

It seems that reading historical writing will always include reading practices of succumbing to enchantment and shock or identifying with characters, whether they be individuals, groups, animals, seas or rivers. Rather than considering how to avoid such components of reading, it is better to consider whether they are productive for the basic function of historical writing, namely, the production and dissemination of knowledge. It is worth not considering them as mutually exclusive modes of reading, but interconnected, complementary or cooperative. Readers may recognise the writing as historical and adopt the genre reading norms prompted by the text and, at the same time, read the text in many other ways that may reinforce the normative reading.

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